to reserve his front-foot play for the policy arena. It was literally time for the big sixes—a sextet of announcements that signalled he would push ahead with his party's welfarism while steering his pet project of revamping Bengaluru.

But first, the caste balance needed to be fashioned anew after Siddaramaiah's exit. Born in the Kuruba shepherding community, he was a living totem of backward class politics whose clout came from the collective mobilising of minorities, OBCs and Dalits, known by the Kannada acronym AHINDA. Shivakumar, on the other hand, is a Vokkaliga, one of the state's two dominant caste blocs. Between them and the Lingayats, they have supplied Karnataka with eight and nine chief ministers, respectively. How was this tilt towards the *ancien régime* to be counterbalanced?

Takeaways

- **Team DKS gets Dalit Dy CM, Parameswara, to fill Sidda's political niche**
- **In his first cabinet meet, DKS unveils new six-point action plan**
- **From free bus passes to Bengaluru revamp, it will test his fiscal skills**

THE DALIT DEPUTY

As a solid Dalit face of the party, Parameswara fits the bill. After a PhD in Plant Physiology from Adelaide, he was groomed back in the day by Rajiv Gandhi. As a young sprinter, he had once done 100 metres in 10.9 seconds. At 75, he has taken his time to rise to the top. He was deputy CM once in 2018, but returns at a time when Rahul Gandhi is giving a pro-Ambedkarite depth to Congress politics. A party rejig was due too, since DKS was also state Congress chief. In steps another OBC leader to fill that post: AICC veteran B.K. Hariprasad, a member of the state legislative council. Siddaramaiah, who declined the offer of a Rajya Sabha seat, preferring to remain an MLA, has been named to the Congress Working Committee.

A TEAM AND A JOB

His imprint is preserved in another way too. The first list of Team DKS largely mirrors the outgoing cabinet, but a notable addition is Siddaramaiah's son Dr Yathindra Siddaramaiah, who makes his ministerial debut. The rest—a mix of veterans and GenNext—have three Vokkaligas, Lingayats and Dalits each, two Kurubas, and one ST, Christian and Muslim each.

Emulating his predecessor, DKS lost no time in getting down to business. Soon after his oath-taking, he convened his first cabinet meeting. On the agenda was a mix of populism and pragmatism: employment exchanges for private sector jobs; Rs 2,000 crore to fix Bengaluru's roads; a one-time amnesty for building bye-law violations; free bus passes for all students up to PG; an extended "Bhu-guarantee" campaign to regularise property titles.

In his maiden press conference, DKS spoke of rural development, farmers' livelihood and urbanisation. "A big shift is taking place with people migrating to towns for work—42 per cent of people live in cities," he said.

His schemes seek to chart a fresh course beyond the Congress's five big-ticket welfare guarantees from 2023. But with a cumulative outgo of Rs 1.21 lakh crore in three years, those have left little fiscal wiggle room. "We will face it, how many ever crores it works out to," says DKS. How those beads fall will be the pattern to watch. ■

▶ PUNJAB

The Great Land Lie

A spurt of concerted ED action puts stolen billions in the PACL case on the way back to duped investors

By **Munish Pandey**

IT WAS LIKE A FABLE, A MILKMAN OWNING THE GALAXY. Yes, Nirmal Singh Bhangoo churned some good cream in his time, cycling from that morning routine in his Attari village all the way to being chief sponsor of IPL team Kings XI Punjab, with Aussie pacer Brett Lee in his promos. It was the zenith for Pearls Agrotech Corporation Ltd (PACL), the real estate/farmland development firm with which he spun his billions. His long stint as an agent at Peerless, the Calcutta-based chit fund, surely helped. A whopping 54.3 million investors from across India fell for the dream he sold: developed farmland, to be handed over when ready.

Bhangoo himself passed on in 2024, and the Rs 68,000 crore he raised thus had vanished with him. Now, a historic restitution process enabled by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) channels it back to the victims. Farmers, daily-wagers, small traders, homemakers—from Punjab, Rajasthan, Bengal, Maharashtra—they'd all

Takeaways

- **FY26 sees ED in overdrive to attach PACL's illegal properties, money from UAE, Australia, NZ**
- **The Bhangoo family faces the heat as agencies spread dragnet**
- **SC-monitored process will see 'restitution' to rightful owners**